The second thing I remember about Perth is the arrival of Gary Kirsten, who had been nominated as coach of India but who was yet to take charge. Gary did not say much at first and just wanted to observe how the Indian players went about their routines. It was Gary who suggested that the team should go cycling in Perth, to get our minds off cricket for a while. It certainly did us a lot of good. At such times net practice is not always the only answer. No one will ever become a Sunil Gavaskar or a Kapil Dev in two days of practice. It is just as important to recharge mentally and it often helps to spend some time together away from the cricket field.

Finally, the support of the fans was particularly memorable. We were 2–0 down in the series and a lot had been written about the fragility of the team on the fast and bouncy WACA track. None of this gloomy talk stopped the Indian fans from coming and lending their support. It was terrific to see the tricolour being waved in the stands and it was a reminder of what the game meant to Indians all round the world. It felt good to have made them proud.

We had proved that the Indian team could play within the spirit of the game both on and off the field.

Fourth Test, Adelaide, 24–28 January 2008

As we prepared for the final Test at Adelaide, Gary asked me if I wanted to bat in the nets and I said I'd prefer to practise to some short-pitched throw-downs. This was the start of a ritual that continued for four years, with Gary throwing hundreds of balls to me before every game. He never seemed to get tired and his commitment to the job was amazing.

When he asked me at Adelaide if I wanted to practise against short throw-downs, I asked him to throw full and fast at me, because I had a feeling Brett Lee would bowl a full-length delivery the moment I went in, as he had got me out with a full delivery at Perth. Sure enough, as soon as I walked out to bat at the Adelaide Oval, Lee bowled a delivery at my pads. I was prepared and instead of playing square, which perhaps he was expecting me to do, I played a straight drive past the umpire for four. After the stroke I looked towards Gary in our dressing room.

I went on to score 153 and we put more than 500 runs on the board, with Sehwag and Bhajji both scoring 63 and Kumble playing a captain's innings down the order of 87. Australia batted just as well in response,